

Cascading Style Sheets

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Cascading Style Sheets (CSS) describe how HTML elements are displayed in a browser. This includes placement, background colour, border style, font weight, and special effects such as animation.

Readability

Until 1996, the styling of webpages was done inline, inside each individual HTML tag. This made code long and cluttered. CSS was created to separate style from content, so developers could focus on a single aspect of the code without being bogged down by other details. Style sheets were written inside an HTML style tag, or in their own separate files known as external style sheets.

```
<p id="main_text" style="color:blue;
background-color:black; font:12px arial;">...</p>
```

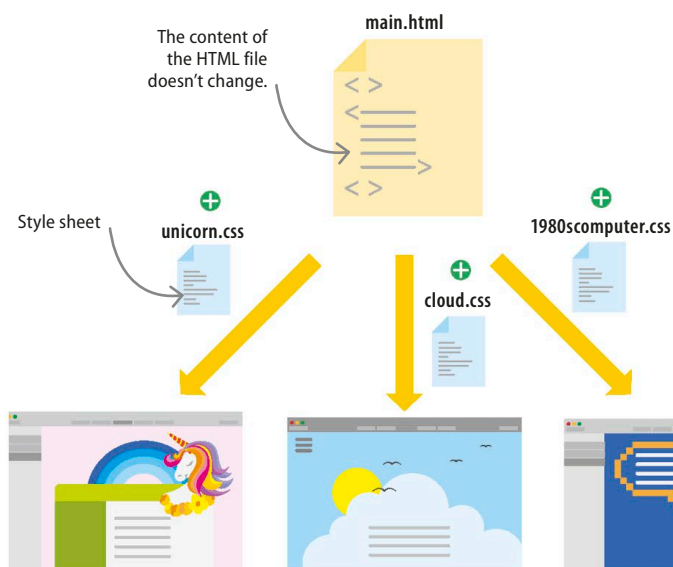
Before CSS

```
<style>
    #main_text {
        color: blue;
        background-color: black;
        font: 12px arial;
    }
</style>
```

After CSS

▷ Recycling

A single style sheet can be used for multiple different HTML files. This not only makes it easier to understand, but also saves developers a lot of time.



Flexibility

Picture a 200-page website with a unicorn theme. One day, the owner decides that a 1980s computer theme would match their products better. Without CSS, the owner would have to dig through all 200 pages, and update them one at a time in order to make the switch. It would be easy to forget a section or make a small mistake. With CSS, only the style sheets need to be changed. The job becomes even easier if there's just one style sheet for multiple pages.

◁ Makeovers

Different style sheets can give the same HTML a complete makeover. This is also useful for creating separate layouts for the mobile versions of a website.